

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

SMALL INCENTIVE Students of a Kolkata Municipal Corporation school line up for meals during Covid

contributing Rs 17,000 a month towards household expenses, thereby helping his family survive the pandemic. The teachers stepped in though, and requested his employers to hold on to his position while Debkanta took some time to appear for his class XII board exams.

Electricity and connectivity remained big challenges. A National Statistical Office (NSO) survey conducted in the 2017-18 academic year had discovered that around 85 per cent of households (rural and urban combined) had no access to a computer (desktop) and around 72 per cent had no access to the internet. More specifically, 92 per cent of rural households in India had no access to a computer and 80 per cent had no access to internet. In states like Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Gujarat, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Odisha, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Tripura and West Bengal, 72-80 per cent had no access to the internet as against the national average of 71.7 per cent. The Indian Researcher survey found that while 43 per cent of students of government schools had no access to digital means of education, 45 per cent of students, mostly first-generation learners, got no educational assistance and support. "Frankly, the worksheets couldn't be assessment indicators. We could easily make out they were not the handiwork of students. Some sheets were just photocopies bearing names of friends or tutorials, which helped solve the questions. Students and parents were more interested in knowing when the mid-day meal ration would be available, rather than when school would physically open. I don't blame them either, with poor network connections and children helping parents out with farm work or domestic chores, the existing arrangement worked fine," said Soumen Das Thakur, a teacher of a school in West Midnapore.

This was the reason several states had been stressing on the urgency to reopen schools. Otherwise, they felt, the learning gaps would become too large to mend, causing higher dropout rates and related social problems, like youth violence, child marriage and even human trafficking.

–Romita Datta

"AS THE PANDEMIC PROGRESSED, CONSTANTLY READING RUMOURS ONLINE CREATED PANIC AMONG YOUNG CHILDREN"

DR UPASANA CHADDHA
Founder, Mindscape Counselling



sleep pattern. His engineer father Charun had to eventually confiscate the Pune-based boy's phone after discovering how he felt compelled to check his phone every few hours. "So much so that one night I found him hunting for his phone at 3 am," says Charun. It began with Facebook Messenger, which he initially used to compare notes with friends after class. Later, he was hooked to social media to the point that he had to seek counselling to ease his social media addiction.

Social media was indeed a major source of anxiety among children during Covid. In a study titled 'Covid-19 and its impact on education, social life and mental health of students', published in *PMC Journal*, a survey of 1,182 students from different educational institutes in Delhi revealed that nearly 70 per cent were suffering from anxiety about the pandemic. "Constantly reading rumours online created panic among young children," says Dr Upasana Chaddha, psychologist and